

# A STUDY OF INDIVIDUAL BOUNDARY-SPANNING COMMUNICATION PATTERNS IN A RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENT SETTING

Ann C. Séror

Département de Management, Université Laval, Ste-Foy, P.Q., G1K 7P4 (Canada)

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## ABSTRACT

*This study explores patterns of individual boundary-spanning communication in a government-managed research and development setting. Individual position in the organization*

*hierarchy and preference for risk, change, and new experiences are the most significant antecedents of general levels of boundary-spanning communication.*

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## INTRODUCTION AND RESEARCH OBJECTIVES

A call has been made to develop new models of organizational systems which include characteristics of both individuals and situations as determinants of individual behavior in organizations (Campbell et al., 1970; James and Jones, 1976). The development of such integrated approaches requires analysis of both macro and micro dimensions of organizations for an understanding of individual behavior and attitudes in organizational settings. The synthesis requires (James and Jones, 1976): (1) the elaboration of models including total organizations, their subsystems and socio-cultural and economic environments; (2) the identification of dimensions of organizations which may be relevant across a variety of service as well as industrial systems in both the public and private sectors; and (3) the study of dynamic organizational processes.

Some recent research has focused on processes of communication across organizational boundaries (House and Rizzo, 1972; Keller and Holland, 1975; Leifer and Huber, 1977; Bacharach and Aiken, 1977; Tushman, 1977, 1979a, b). This research has suggested the importance of the individual perception of task uncertainty as an antecedent of communication across organizational boundaries. Perceived task uncertainty has been defined and operationalized in a variety of ways: ambiguity and conflict (House and Rizzo, 1972; Keller and Holland, 1975), task predictability (Leifer and Huber, 1977), and task variability (Bacharach and Aiken, 1977; Tushman, 1977, 1979a, b). Keller and Holland (1975) found positive but nonsignificant associations between level of individual boundary-spanning activity and perceived role conflict and ambiguity. Tushman (1979a, b) found support for the hypothesis that under the condition of perceived environmental variability or uncertainty, the difference in work unit levels of communication between more and less rou-